

telecom operator beyond providing the network.

"The direct push in Windows Mobile is a part of Microsoft's Exchange ActiveSync protocol. Exchange ActiveSync is the standard for mobile push email and has implementations available for almost all the smartphones and feature phones," shares Khandelwal. He adds that the technology allows a user's email server to communicate directly with his mobile device. When a new email is present at the server, your mobile performs an over-the-air ActiveSync to retrieve it.

The Internet message access protocol (IMAP) works in a similar way as Windows Mobile's HTTP request. Nokia Symbian S60 models use IMAP IDLE functionality with built-in client. As long as the mail client is active on the smartphone, it is notified of changes in the folders on the server. IMAP IDLE issues 'no operation' (NOP) command to the IMAP server at regular intervals to keep the connection active. The basic network use in IDLE command is very small, so it makes very efficient use of bandwidth compared to polling. Most email account servers (like Google and Yahoo) use this protocol as a means of transferring email messages to the email clients.

How can you get push email?

With the advent of widespread mobile broadband access and really simple syndication (RSS) feeds, everyone can use push email technology with the right handset and right software.

For push email services, you need an operating system based smartphone or feature phone that is Internet ready and a data plan from mobile service provider. So you need a handset with at least GPRS capability. You also need an email client software or push email solution downloaded either free of cost or proprietary, to have the emails

Things to consider before opting for push email service

1. Mobile handset and the operating system that supports push email
2. Pros and cons of push email solutions
3. Data plan and charges
4. Password protection for individual usage
5. Software optimisers and upgrades for optimal usage of power

delivered to your local inbox.

For Windows Mobile 2003 SE and earlier, you will need extra software like DATAviz's Roadsyc. Dataviz is also available for Symbian platforms. For Windows Mobile 5 and above, push email is integrated as part of ActiveSync and you don't need additional software. Other push email solutions for Symbian S60 are System SEVEN by SEVEN networks, Mail for Exchange by Nokia, MailX by Bitween and Emoze. BlackBerry has its own BlackBerry Connect software. BlackBerry Connect software also works for handsets like Nokia E61, E62, E70, E65, E50, E90, 9300i and 9500 and Sony M600i, P910i and P990i.

There are different ways in which you can access email on your mobile phone. "For Android phones like Nexus One, the Gmail application is pre-installed, which offers access to Gmail account," explains Fanindra Jain, user of Google's Nexus One. You can download Gmail application program for other handsets as well, to keep all the actions in sync with Gmail server. Phones based on Google's Android OS support push email via ActiveSync from Microsoft Exchange. The email client Seven Beta for Android OS offers push mail across a host of platforms, 'quiet times' when push can be automatically disabled, multiple accounts, server contact search and customisable notifications.

Apple's iPhone provides push email through Apple push notification service (APNS). Every email provider

has to build a separate notification and connect to APNS. So you have Yahoo! push email that sends new message notification over the cell network. Gmail push email integrates Gmail account with your device using IMAP/POP or via Google Sync that uses Microsoft Exchange ActiveSync. Google Sync is available for iPhone and Windows Mobile users.

As the technology involves data transfer, you need to understand your requirement and choose the right plan for yourself. "BlackBerry service has tie-up with the service operators, so there is an option to choose 'email only' service with unlimited download, where you pay flat rate for the BlackBerry service. You will have access to emails via push technology but will not be able to use Web with the minimum package of Rs 299 as offered by most of the operators," explains Gayakwad. There are plans where you can subscribe to email and Internet services, with data plan varying depending on the download. "Another important point to note here is that as you are just notified of the receipt of new message, you do not pay for data until you click to download and view the entire message," he adds.

If you have opted for a push system independent of your mobile service provider, and you are on a flat rate tariff, data usage is not a problem. But if you pay on a per-kilobyte basis, your bill could shoot up especially for heavy usage and downloads. You can sync your calendar, appointments, meetings and live updates with any change that is made on the server using the push email technology.

Configuring your push email

If your company has a BES service, contact your IT administrator to configure your work and personal emails on your BlackBerry device. He will help you with relevant software, settings and security access. Many companies supply their own